FINDING ANTIQUITY, MAKING THE MODERN MIDDLE EAST

ARCHAEOLOGY, EMPIRES, NATIONS

Edited by Guillemette Crouzet and Eva Miller

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Notes

1. A small portion of this text has been adapted from Erin M. B. O'Halloran's *East of Empire: Egypt, India and the World Between the Wars* (Stanford University Press, 2025) and appears here with the permission of the publisher.
2. While the territorial settlement in the Middle East was outlined in the Treaty of Sèvres in 1920 (and renegotiated at Lausanne between 1922–3), it was the opening of the initial Peace Conference in Paris in 1919 which sparked nationalist activity, drew Arab and Zionist delegations (among many others) to the French capital, and saw 'antique nationalism' articulated in presentations to the presiding heads of state. For this reason I refer mainly to the Paris Conference in what follows (see also MacMillan 2001; Manela 2007).
3. Although Britain had established a 'veiled' protectorate in Egypt in the late nineteenth century, this status was formalized in 1914 following the Ottoman entry into the war.
4. Keilo (2021: 9) notes that, technically, Renan viewed Mount Lebanon as lying outside the coastal enclave of the Phoenicians, a detail Lammens and his protégés conveniently overlooked.
5. I am most grateful to Billie Melman for pointing me towards Sukenik. The relationship between father and son is explored in more detail by Neil Asher Silberman (1993).
6. Israeli historians have established that Yadin orchestrated chemical warfare during the 1948 war, poisoning the water and food supplies of Palestinian villages. See Morris and Kedar 2023. On the Palestinian Nakba see also Zuraiq 1948; Pappé 2007.

CHAPTER 7
WHO (OR WHAT) IS A 'PHOENICIAN'? THE COMPLEX HISTORY OF AN ANCIENT PEOPLE IN A MODERN SOCIETY

Marwan Kilani

Lebanon is characterized by high mountains (historically covered with forests, though today they have mostly disappeared) and little cultivable land. It has a long coast with good natural harbours, and it is located at the crossroad of some of the main commercial routes of the Middle East. As a result, the socio-cultural history of Lebanon has been shaped by two complementary trends. On the one hand, as is common in mountainous regions around the world (see e.g. Price 2013: 276), its social landscape has been and still is characterized by a remarkable socio-cultural diversity, with multiple communities, identities and social realities coexisting side by side. On the other hand, because of its strategic position, Lebanon has been an international crossroad and has attracted the interest and attention of external actors since prehistory. Lebanese people have thus been traders and emigrants for millennia,[1] while all the major powers that tried to control the Levant have sooner or later passed through Lebanon. At the mouth of the Nahr el-Kalb, a river just north of Beirut, lies a suggestive place recording the passage of many of these powers. There, on a white cliff facing the sea, celebratory steles mark the passage of armies throughout history. The earliest are Egyptian, left by Ramses II in the thirteenth century BCE, followed by images and inscriptions left by Assyrian, Roman, Byzantine, and Arab rulers, British and French inscriptions, even one celebrating the independence of Lebanon in 1943, and one marking the departure of Israeli troops in 2000.

Lebanon, especially its coast, has been a crossroads for external powers throughout history. At the same time, its unique geographical position has defined it as a distinct socio-cultural area since the Late Bronze Age (*c.* 1550–1200 BCE). The rich historical past and complex socio-cultural landscape of the region have played a crucial role in shaping the history and identity of modern Lebanon. They contribute to internal socio-historical narratives and serve as a socio-cultural interface in its international relations. The unique environment, socio-cultural dynamics, and interactions with the outside world have shaped the identities of those living on the Lebanese coast. These identities, historically quite fluid, are characterized by fuzzy and often permeable boundaries.

As a Bronze Age archaeologist in the region, I have often been confronted with questions about the identity of ancient populations. This includes understanding how the people of Bronze Age Lebanon perceived themselves and effectively communicating these findings to a broader audience. Am I working with 'Phoenician' material? Is my archaeologist's perception of what the term 'Phoenician' encompasses the same as that of

the general public? Were there any 'Phoenicians' at all? This very specific, very archaeological professional experience forms the backdrop for this chapter.

This chapter is structured into two sections. The first provides a concise, albeit non-exhaustive, summary of key dynamics and events shaping the emergence and development of these historical realities. The second delves into considerations on the concepts of 'Phoenicians' and the 'Phoenician past', and their use in archaeology.

Moreover, this chapter aims to employ the development of the concept of a 'Phoenician' past in Lebanon as a Near Eastern case study to illustrate the intricate and non-linear nature of these dynamics and developments. The historical summary in the initial section should thus be regarded accordingly: the focus there is not on the single events, but on the complexity of the resulting picture when we combine them together. In this respect, my chapter does not lay claim to ground-breaking innovation in the historical narrative it presents: in recent years several scholars far more qualified than me have worked on these topics and on the history of Lebanon (Firro 2002; Kaufman 2004; Ṭarābulsī 2008; Harris 2015), and my modest contribution has very little to add in that respect to the rich and compelling body of work they have produced.

Similarly, I do not assert that my chapter provides an exhaustive or complete account of 'what truly happened': historiography is often a question of perspectives, and in a case as complex as that of Lebanon a myriad of valid viewpoints exists, encompassing a large spectrum of experiences and ideas. Attempting to comprehensively represent all these perspectives within the confines of this brief chapter would be an impossible task. Therefore, I extend my apologies from the outset to any readers who may find that this concise contribution does not fully represent their perspectives or does so differently than they would have preferred – but in a way, the (impossible?) challenge of including and properly representing all voices and all perspectives is also part of the complexity of these realities that I aim to illuminate here.

Phoenicians and modern Lebanese historical narratives

History, or better, narratives about specific historical phases, have obviously been used and are still used in the definition and redefinition of Lebanese identity/ies. Not surprisingly, the diversity (and fragmentation) of Lebanese society means that multiple historical narratives coexist in Lebanon, with different communities and players selecting, emphasizing or minimizing different aspects of the (real or mythical) history of the country. Yet, there is one element of the long Lebanese history that has played and still plays a crucial role in Lebanese national-historical narratives and imaginary, both within Lebanon and abroad. This element is the Phoenician past. I will come back to who or what the Phoenicians were (or were not) later in the chapter, but for now, it suffices to say that the term is generally understood to refer to ancient maritime traders and seafarers from the Northern Levantine coast (Lebanon and nearby regions especially north of it), recognized for their influential role in maritime trade and the spread of some cultural innovations like the alphabet during the first millennium BCE.

The 'Phoenicians' and 'Phoenician antiquity' is certainly not the most dominant historical reference within Lebanese society. Yet, it is undeniably there, and acts like a suffused, widespread, lingering underlying motif. This motif manifests in multiple aspects of Lebanese daily life, such as the celebration of the Phoenician alphabet as the origin of all world alphabets on £1,000 notes (see Figure 7.1), or the setting of the exhibition at the National Museum in Beirut, where the sarcophagus of the Iron Age king Hiram welcomes the visitors in the main hall, or through the real or virtual discussions, activities, and initiatives of individuals or small groups of citizens.[2]

At a first glance, this whole emphasis on the Phoenicians might appear somewhat counterintuitive. When one visits, for example, Italy, it is easy to understand why the Roman past is central in Italian historical narratives: its traces are scattered and visible everywhere, often in monumental forms. This is hardly the case of the Phoenician past in Lebanon. It is true that the Bronze and Iron Age populations of Lebanon played



Figure 7.1 Lebanese 1,000£ note with the Phoenician alphabet and its historical descendants up to the Latin alphabet on one side and up to the Arabic alphabet on the other. Image produced by Padres Hana.

central roles in various major human achievements, such as the development of maritime networks in the Mediterranean and beyond, or the spread of the alphabet outside the Levant.[3] However, from a purely archaeological standpoint, the historical phases typically linked with the Phoenicians are not the most characteristic, well-documented or impressive episodes of Lebanese history. Lebanon is rich in archaeological remains. Impressive Hellenistic and Roman ruins can be seen everywhere, and they include the biggest temple and the biggest hippodrome of the Roman Empire (in Baalbek and Tyre respectively), as well as some well preserved and very suggestive smaller shrines (e.g. in Bziza, and Niha). Medieval castles (e.g. in Byblos and Sidon) and later Ottoman buildings (from Beit ed-Dine Palace and the imposing Grand Serail in Beirut, currently the prime minister's headquarters, to the modest train station in Beirut) are also a distinctive feature of many Lebanese cities. By contrast, although Bronze and Iron Age remains have indeed been found all across Lebanon, they are objectively modest and often unimpressive, save a handful of exceptions. In this respect, Byblos stands out for its Bronze Age fortifications, temples where thousands of objects from foundation deposits have been found, and royal tombs, including some untouched ones dating to the Middle Bronze Age that yielded real treasures. The Iron Age layers, however, are very poorly attested in the city. Moreover, most of these Phoenician traces have been recovered through archaeological excavations, often recent ones, and have not long been part of the visible Lebanese landscape – unlike later Graeco-Roman monuments. So, how did we get there? Why are the 'Phoenicians' such an important cultural reference in identity narratives in and about Lebanon?

A historical summary of Lebanese Phoenicianism

The nineteenth century

The first historical-archaeological survey of the region that is now Lebanon took place when it was under Ottoman control, performed by the French scholar Ernest Renan, in 1860 to 1861. Philosopher and historian, Renan is known for his works on religious history, and his ideas about the nature of nations. These interests, and his Christian faith, certainly shaped his mission. Moreover, the mission was financed by Napoleon III of France and was an integral part of the king's policy toward the *Chretiens d'Orient*. This, in turn, was part of the larger French political ambitions and of its competition with Britain in the regions controlled by the Ottoman Empire.

This was a troubled yet crucial period for Lebanon. At the beginning of the nineteenth century, the region was divided between two main dominant actors competing for power. Official power was held by the Christian Maronite community.[4] The emirs of Lebanon of the time, from the Shihab family, belonged to that community.[5] However, large parts of Mount Lebanon were controlled by Druze communities.[6] The area involved in these disputes roughly corresponded to that of modern Lebanon and included both the coast and the Beqaa Valley. In the 1830s the situation degenerated, leading to increased

instability and various revolts. These conflicts were fuelled also by the interests of external powers: the Ottomans backed the Druzes, the French backed the Maronites and the ruling emir, the British backed the Druzes in an anti-French stand, while Muhammad Ali of Egypt supported the Maronites within his own anti-Ottoman agenda. Strategic and economic considerations played a role, too. As stated earlier, Lebanon has always been a crucial crossroads. At the time the region was also a centre of silk production, which was mainly exported to Europe. By the mid-nineteenth century, the conflict was out of control: open revolts of the Druzes against the Maronites were followed by an Ottoman intervention in 1842 that resulted in a partition into two districts. The partition did not lead to a lasting peace, as the Maronites revolted in 1860 triggering what would become a wider civil war. Massacres followed on both sides, but the Druzes managed to get the upper hand and to push the Maronites back into a few strongholds in the mountains, until in the late summer of 1860 the French Emperor Napoleon III, citing a treaty of 1523 in which France assumed the role of protector of the Christians within the Ottoman Empire, pushed for a European intervention to impose a political solution. This intervention was formalized in September 1860 and took the form of an expeditionary force of 12,000 soldiers. France contributed half the forces, while the remaining troops were provided by Austria, Great Britain, Prussia and Russia.

France recognized the Druze control on the ground, and the Ottomans agreed to the creation of a Christian Maronite enclave, which had the status of a semi-autonomous Mutasarrifate with a Christian governor. This enclave was geographically limited to the costal territory West of Mount Lebanon, south of Tripoli, and north of Sidon. It did not comprise any major city, as Beirut was cut off as an enclave within it. The European troops, sent in agreement with the Ottoman government, had the task of re-establishing order and assuring the partition of the territory, and stayed in Lebanon until 1861.

Renan's mission took place in the aftermath of these events. In fact, as he himself stated (Renan 1864: 1–2), he saw the dispatching of French troops to Lebanon as a great opportunity giving him both access to the region and a trained European workforce for his excavations and surveys. He published his results in a book titled *Mission de Phénicie* (Mission of Phoenicia). This title is significant, because it shows the mindset with which this French explorer approached the country: Renan was not interested in contemporary 'Lebanon' and in 'Lebanese' archaeological heritage in general. Rather he was mainly looking for the 'Phoenician' past of the country, and secondarily for traces left by other classical civilizations that passed through the area, such as the Egyptians, the Greeks and the Romans, or by the European Crusaders. In other words, he did not go to Lebanon to explore it and let the evidence present itself. He went there to find the material traces of those few, selected civilizations described in classical (and secondarily biblical) sources. Phoenicia was of interest for him not in itself, but because Phoenicians were actors in Greek, Roman and biblical histories. Similarly, Phoenicia had to exist in Lebanon, had to be the main historical reality there, and had to be found as such in the archaeological evidence, because the classical sources talked about it. Obviously, this classic-centric perspective, and this classical 'Phoenician' identity sought in, and imposed on, Lebanese antiquities was not Renan's invention. Rather, it was the fruit of a wider European

mentality and imaginary of the time. Schliemann's search for the Homeric Troy, which involved the destruction of multiple later archaeological layers he considered unimportant, is a good example of another manifestation of the same mentality.

Renan's colonial perspective extended beyond the past to the contemporary Lebanese population, in which respect he also reflected wider European attitudes of his time. His disdain for local, Indigenous populations, both Christian and Muslim, was explicit. He viewed them as inferior, barbarous or 'lowered' races (Renan 1864: 13–14, 24, 837–8). He believed the modern Lebanese, regardless of faith, had no ties to the ancient Phoenicians, whom he saw as 'dead'. Yet, he acknowledged that mountain communities had resisted Arab influence longer than others and detected remnants of the 'Phoenician race' in some individuals. He had some (limited) sympathy for the Maronites (Renan 1864: 13–14), but this seems to be mainly because of the closeness of their faith to Catholicism, and because of their willingness to help him and the French – unsurprising, considering that the French Empire acted as the main financial supporter and political ally of the Maronites.

However, he rejected any kind of continuity between the Phoenicians and the Maronites, whom he considered as coming from Antioch, north of Lebanon, today in Turkey (Renan 1864: 216–17). More interesting, he emphasized that the Maronites themselves proudly rejected any links to earlier pagan populations, and he admitted teasing them by saying that pagans lived in the same regions in antiquity (Renan 1864: 217). Furthermore, Renan noted several individuals of varying faiths who collected antiquities out of personal curiosity or interest (Renan 1864: 23, 144). However, he argued that, overall, the local population showed little enthusiasm for archaeology unless there was a prospect of financial gain or the discovery of treasure (Renan 1864: 14, 818). Renan's brief mission and subsequent report hold great significance. They marked the explicit introduction of a series of ideas and ideological frameworks that would profoundly shape the country's history and its relationship with its historical and archaeological heritage to this day.

Before the First World War

In the decades leading up to the First World War, Lebanon experienced a period of relative calm. Following the withdrawal of European troops, control returned to Ottoman and local authorities. The partition established in 1860 remained in place, contributing to stability and modest prosperity in the region during that period. To my knowledge, no official Western archaeological expeditions are known to have visited Lebanon. However, the Ottomans conducted archaeological excavations in Lebanon, such as those in Sidon led by Osman Hamdi Bey, the founder and head of the Istanbul Archaeological Museums, with finds mostly brought back to Istanbul. French Jesuits also played a significant role in promoting the study of local archaeology, particularly after the establishment of the Université Saint-Joseph in Beirut in 1875 (Kaufman 2004: 23, 29). During this relatively politically quiet period, two noteworthy developments emerged. First, Christian Lebanese elites and intellectuals, both in Lebanon and within the diaspora in France and Alexandria, began to embrace the idea of a direct ancestral connection to the classical

Phoenicians (Naaman 2015). This 'Phoenician myth' predominantly found traction among members of secular circles with European or Jesuit education, rather than within the traditional Maronite clergy (Kaufman 2004: 38). The latter was also interested in their Lebanese past, but still understood it as detached from the pre-Christian pagans, as already observed by Renan.

Simultaneously, France refined its colonial theories and strategies during this era. Following the perceived failure of earlier assimilation policies, a new doctrine of 'association' emerged in French colonial thinking after 1870. In contrast with the earliest approach, which aimed to reshape colonial societies along the French model, the new theory aimed at controlling the colonial entities through a 'politics of races'. The idea was to emphasize (or create) ethnic divisions and then to co-opt selected local groups and elites by providing them with new cultural and historical narratives, or myths, that highlighted affinities with the French nation (Betts 2005, esp. 106–9). This strategy created ideological bridges and collaborative colonial relationships that benefited France with minimal direct investment (Kaufman 2004: 13). These two processes unfolded in parallel until the First World War.

From the First World War to independence in 1943

Unlike neighbouring territories, Lebanon was not directly embroiled in the conflict of the First World War. However, the Lebanese Mutasarrifate suffered greatly from both Allied and Ottoman embargoes, severely impacting its vital silk trade. The subsequent reduction in food imports, essential for the mountainous region, coupled with a locust infestation, led to a devastating famine. This famine claimed the lives of approximately 200,000 people between 1915 and 1918, amounting to roughly half of the region's population.

After the First World War, Lebanon became a type A Mandate under French tutelage. At that point, the authorities of the Lebanese Mutasarrifate requested a border expansion to create a 'Greater Lebanon', encompassing additional territories to the south, north and in the Beqaa Valley. They argued that the Mutasarrifate was too small to be viable, citing the recent famine as evidence. This proposal also marked the first official mention of the distinctive 'Phoenician' identity of the (Christian) Lebanese population, supporting the case for an independent Lebanese state (Kaufman 2004: 86). The proposal was accepted, but Lebanon remained under French administration until 1943.

The shift from the Mutasarrifate to 'Greater Lebanon' altered the demography of the country. While initially most of the population was Maronite, with the extension of the borders, other communities and traditions became part of the new 'Greater Lebanon'. France, however, managed to draw the borders to ensure the preservation of Christian primacy. In contrast, the territories of the once-powerful Druze communities were divided among Lebanon, Syria, and British Palestine. Today, they make up only 5 per cent of Lebanon's population, and the fragmentation of their historical territory among different countries in the new map drawn by the British and French victors of the First World War also makes them a minority community everywhere else.

While administering the Levant Mandates, France faced an ideological challenge: reconciling its historical role as protector of Eastern Christians with its new identity as a Muslim-orientated colonial power after its North African conquests and its new post-Ottoman control over Syria and its large Muslim population. In Lebanon, the French administration's solution combined the 'politics of races' with the ideas circulating among Lebanese Christians, thus promoting a 'Phoenician' identity in Lebanon, and an 'Arab' identity in Syria (Dakhli 2011; Kaufman 2004: 113). Public education and archaeology became vectors for these ideas. 'French institutes' and museums in Damascus and Beirut played a crucial role, focusing on Muslim archaeology in Damascus and exclusively on Phoenician, Frankish-Crusade and Christian archaeology in Beirut. French archaeologists like Jean Pierre Marie Montet and Maurice Dunand excavated pre-Islamic Lebanese sites, while the Jesuit Université Saint-Joseph aligned education with this political agenda. The academic journal *Syria*, founded in 1920, furthered these goals. In its first issue (1920: 1–2), the editor of the journal claimed:

> Our program can be summarized in two sentences: to cultivate in Syria[7] a passion for the art and antiquities of the country and to promote a broader understanding abroad of Syrian arts from all periods. The Syria review aims to serve as a bridge between the French intellectual community and the Syrian elite, providing them with the opportunity for fruitful collaboration.[8]

In 1928, the Lebanese scholar Maurice Chéhab, a Maronite, was appointed conservator of the National Museum in Beirut after studying history and archaeology at various universities in Paris. The political value of archaeology was fully exploited by the French during the *Exposition coloniale internationale* in Paris, in 1931, where the Levantine states, being type A Mandates rather than colonies, were represented through a pavilion dedicated to their archaeology and their classical past (Trégan 2013).

However, the emergence of a 'Phoenician' identity in Lebanon should not be solely attributed to the French. France played a role in promoting it through colonial institutions, but 'Phoenicianism' originated with the Christian elites in Lebanon and the diaspora, during the Mutasarrifate period, preceding the French Mandate. At the same time, as Kaufman (2004: 27) says, 'The idea that the Maronites were in fact "*les Français du Levant*" was a wish made by both sides – the Maronites, who entrusted their hopes to the French, and the French who, on the one hand, had sincere feelings for the Maronites and, on the other, aspired to find a perfect collaborator for their colonial aspirations in the region.'

Opposition to such ideology did exist, and it grew stronger in the 1930s, in the wake of the general turmoil that affected the region. As Lebanon's independence from the French Mandate approached, two opposing camps emerged. One supported the creation of a Lebanese state independent from the Syrian part of the French Mandate, while the other emphasized the connection of Lebanese communities with Syria and the Arab world. The 'Phoenician' identity played a role in shaping this debate, although it was not its primary focus. Moreover, while the main divide was along Christian and Muslim

lines, the division was not clear-cut. Multiple other factors were intermingled with it, and remarkable exceptions existed on both sides. Some Christians identified as Arabs and opposed independence, while some Muslims recognized (or believed in) Lebanon's Phoenician past. The latter often did that by stressing the classical tradition of an Arabian (and thus, by extension, 'Arab') origin of the Phoenicians (Herodotus, *Histories* VII.89), thus reconciling their contemporary Arab identity with a Lebanese Phoenician-but-ultimately-Arabian past. As the creation of an independent Lebanese state became inevitable, these latter positions gained prominence.

From independence to civil war

After declaring independence in 1943, Lebanon experienced a few decades of relative stability and prosperity. During this period, two currents of Phoenicianism coexisted. The narrative of Phoenicians as a shared and distinctive heritage gained adherents. From the 1940s, Phoenicianist ideas entered the national narrative, and grew in popularity among Muslims, especially the Sunni bourgeoisie. No longer was it an identity meaningful only to Christian elites. The notion of a connection between Phoenicians and Arabs, based on the former's supposed origin in the Arabian Peninsula, contributed to this trend. Phoenician symbols and imagery also became prominent in daily life. By the mid-1940s, prevailing beliefs in Lebanon, emphasized the country as a crossroads of civilizations, credited the ancient Lebanese with inventing the alphabet, and depicted the Lebanese as natural-born merchants for 6,000 years. This Phoenician past influenced education, daily life and even commercial products like cigarette packaging (Kaufman 2004: 130–1).

The older Phoenicianism, which regarded Phoenicians as exclusive ancestors of the Maronites, and the old Christian and Muslim opposition to it which saw Phoenicianism as a foreign colonial interference, still existed but became marginalized among both Christians and Muslims.

The years of the civil war, 1970s–90s

In the 1970s, the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, the influx of Palestinian refugees and regional developments destabilized the country and sparked a 15-year civil war in Lebanon, from 1975 to 1990. During this period, Phoenicianism regained prominence as an ideological pillar for Christian nationalist factions like Kata'eb (Phalanges). These groups, which mixed elements of European-style nationalism and ethnonationalism (Makhoul 2019: 104) with radical Christianity and anti-Muslim positions, aimed to establish a semi- or fully independent Christian canton on Lebanon's coast, emphasizing the idea that Maronites were direct descendants of the Phoenicians, distinct from Arab, non-Christian communities. Interestingly, this self-perceived non-Arab and anti-Arab ideology occasionally led to informal collaboration with Israeli forces occupying parts of Lebanon,[9] as Israelis were seen as equally non-Arab and thus as potential allies against perceived Arab/Muslim threats. I am not aware of any attempt to justify such collaboration

through an ideologically explicit 'Canaanite' connection between Phoenicians and ancient Israelites, but such a narrative may have indeed been circulating at the time.

However, one must be careful here: Phoenicianism did play a role in the narratives of these groups, but not necessarily a dominant one, as indicated by the limited use of Phoenician symbolism in their propaganda.[10] During the civil war, Phoenicianism served as an acknowledged but implicit framework for other ideological narratives, rather than being a dominant force guiding the political choices of these groups. Unlike neighbouring Israel, where the historical myth and the idea of reviving an ancient Israelite state were and still are fundamental to Zionist ideology, in Lebanon there was no intention to establish a 'Neo-Phoenician' state. Somewhat ironically, during the civil war, the National Archaeological Museum of Beirut ended up being on the so-called Green Line, the neutral no-man zone that divided the city. By the end of the 1980s, however, the Christian factions were being cornered, and Muslim factions such as Hezbollah gained the upper hand.

The years after the civil war

Between 1989 and 1990, Syria brokered the end of hostilities in Lebanon and sent troops to enforce peace, remaining in Lebanon until 2006 when the peaceful Cedar Revolution led to their withdrawal. Obviously, a declared pan-Arabic/pan-Arabist Syria supporting an explicitly Islamic Hezbollah was ideologically deeply opposed to Phoenicianist narratives. The Ta'if Accord that ended the war embodied these positions, emphasizing the Arab nature of Lebanon. This was explicitly stated by the second paragraph of the agreement itself, which reads: 'Lebanon is Arab in belonging and identity. It is an active and founding member of the Arab League and is committed to the league's charter' (§I.B). As a result, the exclusivist Phoenician historical narrative lost any official standing it may once have had. In fact, disillusioned debates about and against the exclusive form of Phoenicianism, and about historical narratives and ideologies in general, started already during the Civil War. It is worth quoting Kaufman (2004: 246–7) at length, in his analysis of the Lebanese historian Kamal Salibi's work:

> In 1988, when the cannons were still roaring and Lebanese were killing each other in horrendous numbers, Kamal Salibi published his soul-searching book *A House of Many Mansions*. In his conclusion, he wrote a statement antithetical to Renan's view regarding the role of fabricated history in national formation. 'For any people to develop and maintain a sense of political community', Salibi wrote, 'it is necessary that they share a common vision of their past'. For communities with natural solidarity, Salibi continued, fictionalized history can suffice for this purpose. However, such self-deception can only work in communities confident of their unity and solidarity. Divided societies cannot afford this imaginary luxury. To achieve solidarity these societies must 'know and understand the full truth of the past'. Lebanon, Salibi concludes, is a case in point. As a politically divided society, Lebanon is condemned to know and understand its past, if it seeks to survive. No

> political settlement could last unless Lebanon came to terms with its history and adjusted to its veracities. The Lebanese had to know exactly who they were, why and how they came to be Lebanese. Otherwise they would continue to be so many tribes and fail to overcome the cleavages that tear their society apart.
>
> If the positivist vision of history 'as it actually was', is left aside, what radiates from Salibi's words is an engaging statement that argues succinctly that Lebanon needs to reevaluate its history to survive as a national community. And so, in A House of Many Mansions, Salibi, who, prior to 1975, was one of the prime historians to provide the Lebanese with their [false?] national history, deconstructs this historiography, which he himself helped to construct, and offers a new evaluation of the most important foundation myths of Lebanon. He disputes the myth of the Emirate as the precursor of modern Lebanon; he challenges the view of the Maronite community as a (Christian) rose among (Muslim) thorns; he contests the theories of the Mountain as a refuge for minorities and as a distinct autonomous region within the Ottoman Empire; and, finally, he also critically analyzes the phenomenon of Phoenicianism in Lebanon, charging it as one of the most faulty and historically groundless ideas conceived in Lebanon.

Assessing phenomena in contemporary societies is always challenging. However, it seems that in the years following the civil war, Lebanese society has been attempting to redefine its narratives using a more balanced and objective approach. This, however, is an ongoing process. Additionally, the rise of the internet and social networks has provided a new platform for the expression of exclusivist and extremist Phoenicianist ideas.

Nevertheless, the emergence after the war of critical works scrutinizing Lebanon's historical narratives and identity indicates a process of deconstruction and introspective analysis of its historical identity. During this time, the National Museum reopened, and new archaeological explorations and excavations commenced, including those in Sidon and Beirut linked to postwar developments in the city, and this renewed interest for archaeology lasts until today (see e.g. the Northern Lebanon Project, the new excavations in Byblos, or those in Anfeh with their Byzantine and medieval discoveries). While the museum is still primarily centred on Lebanon's Bronze and Iron Age, it has embraced a modern and inclusive approach to archaeological research, welcoming scholars from diverse backgrounds and producing remarkable results of high academic value. This is evident in the high-quality papers regularly published in BAAL, the principal Lebanese academic archaeological journal affiliated with the museum and published by the Lebanese Direction Générale des Antiquités and Ministry of Culture. Furthermore, the early twenty-first century saw a growing popular interest in Lebanon's Ottoman heritage (Davie 2009), indicating the society's willingness to address also this recent and sensitive historical period.

Unfortunately, these developments were once again disrupted in recent years. Recent geopolitical challenges, including the Syrian civil war and the Covid-19 pandemic, have overshadowed discussions of Lebanese historical narratives. Hopefully, the situation will improve soon and will mark only a pause, not a setback, in the Lebanese elaboration of its historical narratives.

Notably, a substantial Lebanese diaspora exists, with more Lebanese residing abroad than in their home country, particularly among the Christian Lebanese. The Lebanese diaspora often uphold Phoenicianist ideas linked to a nostalgic view of an idealized homeland. This diaspora, especially in Europe, played a key role in the emergence of Phoenicianism in the early twentieth century, an influence that persists today. However, exploring this aspect goes beyond the scope of this discussion.

Conclusion: And what about the 'Phoenicians'?

So, who, or better what, is a 'Phoenician'? I have explicitly avoided this question until now, because this, in fact, is one of the main issues: there is (and there can be) no single definition of what or who the 'Phoenicians' were (or are). Rather, the definition itself is shaped by, and shapes in turn, the perception of and approaches to history by those who use it, be they whole societies, groups within societies, individuals, laymen, archaeologists, Lebanese, non-Lebanese, both inside and outside Lebanon. People may agree on a few core features, elements, and tropes, like the Phoenicians being credited with inventing the alphabet, although these markers may not be as obvious as they might seem.[11] Yet the wider boundaries and characteristics of this 'Phoenician-ness' can vary significantly.

For instance, in Lebanon the definition of 'Phoenicians' is often based on ancient Greek descriptions, thus encompassing inhabitants of the northern Levantine coast in classical times but also including their historical Bronze Age predecessors, as Herodotus claims Phoenicians arrived in Lebanon from Arabia millennia before his era. By contrast, Carthaginians, well documented in classical literary and historical sources as some of the primary rivals/enemies of Roman Republic in the third to second centuries BCE, have an ambiguous status. Carthage, on the coast of what is now Tunisia, was founded by Phoenician descendants, but is not widely seen as 'Lebanese' (or 'Lebanese diaspora'). Anecdotally, in my personal and professional experience, I don't think I have ever met a Lebanese person who views the Punic Wars between Rome and Carthage as an essential part of their Lebanese/Phoenician history.

Conversely, European and American archaeologists usually narrow 'Phoenicians' to the Iron Age or first millennium BCE, but extend the category geographically to include later Punic, Carthaginian societies. As a result, many Western universities have departments or programs focusing on Phoenician-Punic studies, often linked with Classics departments and separate from those focusing on the Bronze Age Levant. In Western academic output, conferences about the 'Phoenicians' rarely feature the Bronze Age societies of Lebanon, and publications mainly concentrate on the Iron Age and delve deeply into the Punic context, with only brief mentions, if any, of Bronze Age precursors. This Western view of the 'Phoenicians' is driven by three main principles. Firstly, from an ideological point of view, Western societies are primarily interested in the broader Mediterranean 'Phoenician' phenomenon of the first millennium BCE, when Phoenician traders established colonies across the region, rather than in its Bronze Age origins, as this allows them to connect it with (or appropriate it for?) their own historical narratives.

In this frame, the 'Phoenicians' are recast as a major player in a (Mediterranean and European-centred) 'world history', for instance as founders of European cities and societies, especially in Spain and southern Italy, or as participants in Graeco-Roman historical narratives. Secondly, the term 'Phoenicians' is not found in Phoenician sources; instead, the Iron Age Lebanese referred to themselves as Canaanites. Therefore, Western scholars often argue that the label 'Phoenician' should exclusively refer to the Levantine reality known to the Greeks during the Iron Age (*c.* 1200–586 BCE).[12] Thirdly, Western academic archaeology conventionally divides history into distinct Bronze and Iron Ages, the latter roughly corresponding to the first millennium BCE. While it is certainly true that the transition from Bronze to Iron Age was marked by significant socio-cultural and geopolitical changes, like any historical periodization, this division is a conventional framework and should not override the available evidence. In mainstream academia, however, the Bronze/Iron Age division often becomes a predefined, over-imposed frame that dictates the boundaries of research. This is especially true in scholarship dealing with the Middle East, including Lebanon.

As a Bronze Age Levant archaeologist, I feel uncomfortable with both these definitions of 'Phoenicians'. Although changes did occur, it is undeniable that the Lebanese coast shows significant continuity from at least the Middle Bronze Age into the Iron Age. This challenges the Western academic construct of a division between a 'Phoenician' society in the Iron Age and a 'non-defined' or explicitly 'non-Phoenician' one in the Bronze Age. At the same time, the 'Phoenicians' were clearly part of a geographically wider Canaanite cultural ensemble that extended beyond Lebanon, both further north and south, especially during the Bronze Age. Yet, there is no evidence that these Bronze Age Canaanite populations shared an explicit, common socio-cultural identity, and certainly not a 'Phoenician' one – the concept of 'Phoenicians' as we understand it today is indeed a Greek invention and projection. The traditional Lebanese definition of Phoenicians is at odds with both these points.

These widely varying understandings of what the ancient Lebanese past actually consists of, and the difficulty in finding appropriate terms and labels to refer to it without overloading it with anachronistic (and ideological) nuances, prompts essential questions for us archaeologists, and for the way we archaeologists interact and communicate with our wider publics. Can these realities be reconciled, and is it archaeology's task to try to do so? In my work, one of the strategies I adopt to be as neutral as possible is to use geographical definitions, such as the names of regions, cities, kingdoms, and other documented regional political entities as primary identity frames. I therefore talk about 'the populations of the Lebanese coast' or 'the inhabitants of Byblos'. This approach, which allows for more neutrality, is ideal for academic discussion, and is indeed common in academic circles among scholars inside and outside Lebanon. However, it faces challenges in broader contexts.

Public outreach and the popularization of archaeological research present a particularly obvious and problematic example. Recent exhibitions in the West about the 'Phoenicians' continue to use problematic definitions, often reinforcing outdated stereotypes of the Phoenicians as a 'mysterious' population.[13] This is not only a question of a putative scientific

accuracy. The often-marginal involvement of Lebanese scholars, and especially the marginal representation of Lebanese academic voices that find little space in Western-defined narratives of these contemporary Western academic and museographical endeavours is another, still present issue. As the historical vicissitudes of Lebanon show, the construction of identities and narratives for past societies can profoundly impact and shape modern communities. This process is intricate, influenced by various forces, and at times circular, with historical narratives influencing modern communities, and modern communities redefining those narratives. While I would certainly not go so far as to claim that wars were fought over the concept of 'Phoenicians', I think we can safely say that this concept has indeed influenced and shaped the civil war in Lebanon. It is thus clear that the terminology we use is meaningful, and archaeologists and historians must be aware of the potential implications of their work beyond the academic realm. In this respect, it is clear in contemporary professional standards in archaeology would discourage us scholars from making broad assertions about the contemporary populations based on their connection to ancient pasts, akin to the sweeping statements made by Ernest Renan during his survey of Lebanon in 1860–61. However, the statements we articulate, the sites we excavate, and the knowledge we choose to emphasize inevitably shape modern perceptions of how we, whoever we may be, are interconnected with the past. Recognizing the political dimensions of the past in the regions we excavate is thus crucial for every practicing archaeologist. Acknowledging this is an initial, relatively straightforward step. The challenging part lies in addressing the following questions: What actions, if any, should we take? How should we proceed, and in what contexts: professional, public, private? These questions may not have definitive answers, but they are undoubtedly worth asking.

Notes

1. Trade between Byblos and Egyptian Pharaohs dates back to the Early Bronze Age, while the Iron Age Phoenicians and their Carthaginian descendants are famous for their colonies, trade, and exploration. In the nineteenth century, Lebanese migrated to Europe, Australia and the Americas, leading to a diaspora now outnumbering the population in Lebanon (Verdeil and Dewailly 2019).
2. From the frequent incorporation of Phoenician references in the names of Lebanese restaurants worldwide to more organized initiatives such as the websites https://phoenicia.org or www.lebaneselanguage.org.
3. Although likely not its invention: the Proto-Canaanite and Ugaritic alphabets predate the Phoenician alphabet.
4. The Maronites, primarily linked to Lebanon, are an Eastern Christian community incorporating Eastern liturgical practices within the Roman Catholic Church framework.
5. The Shihab family was originally Sunni Muslim with a strong tradition of intermarriage with Druze families (and thus with several Druze members), but the branch that hold the power at the time had converted into Maronite Christianity (Mishaqah 1988: 23).
6. The Druzes, a distinct ethnic-religious community mainly in Lebanon, Syria, Israel and Jordan, follow a monotheistic faith originating in the eleventh century. Their beliefs combine elements from Islam, Gnosticism and other philosophies.

7. Here 'Syria' refers to both modern Syria and Lebanon.
8. Author's translation.
9. See e.g. the Sabra and Shatila massacre. In general, from 1976 onwards, Kata'eb received covert financial and military support from Israel (Rabinovich 1985: 63).
10. See e.g. the contemporary posters at www.signsofconflict.com.
11. But see note 5.
12. The Phoenician name is complex: while absent in Canaanite sources, a suspiciously similar name appears in Early Bronze Age Egyptian sources.
13. See e.g. the recent exhibition 'New Perspectives on Phoenician Sailing' at the New York Metropolitan Museum in 2014.

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